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MILOS BICANSKI Getty Images

A SCIENTIST PICKS OUT plastic particles found in marine samples at a research center near Athens.

Industry execs long knew of microplastics

Scientists' concern about bits infiltrating the body goes back to a 1974 meeting.

BY SUSANNE RUST

Scientists today say we're just beginning to understand the harm that the tiny bits of plastic we drink, eat and breathe are doing to the human body.

But recently discovered chemical company documents dating back several decades show that industry scientists have long been aware of — and concerned about — the way microplastic particles migrate beyond the gut in animals and humans, depositing in important organs. And the potential for that knowledge to affect the plastic food packaging industry.

Their concern goes back to 1974 and a scientific meeting at a New York City hotel, where a German gastroenterologist presented a scientific paper that showed for the first time that ingested particles like microplastics could infiltrate the rest of the body.

His presentation was largely overlooked by the government scientists in attendance but became a point of worried discussion among company scientists.

A "horror story" was how one company executive described how that research was received.

The word "microplastics" had yet to be coined, but Berlin researcher Gerhard Volkheimer showed that tiny bits of swallowed plastic PVC could slip through the intestinal lining of animals and travel through the blood and lymph to the brain, liver and other internal body parts.

According to Matthew Campen, a professor of pharmaceutical research at the University of New Mexico and a leading researcher in microplastics and human health, the same process applies to any small, impermeable particle including polyethylene, polypropylene and PET — the plastics that dominate today's market and the microplastics found in human bodies.

The presence of these particles in human bodies has been linked to heart disease, inflammation and

[See **Microplastics,** A6]

JUDGES QUESTION FEDS ON BALLOT BLOCKING

The panel asks how the administration's request in California squares with the law.

BY KEVIN RECTOR

In a rare Sunday hearing, a federal appeals court judge appointed by President Trump questioned how the Trump administration's request to intervene in California's ongoing midterm election in order to force state officials to set aside 20,000 ballots from voters whose citizenship it questions squares with the U.S. Constitution.

Judge Mark J. Bennett said that while the executive branch is "unhappy" with what California law requires for ensuring voters are citizens, the state has the right to determine the manner of its elections under the Elections Clause of the Constitution and Congress has not challenged that process, despite having the ability to do so.

"It seems to me that you want us to issue an injunction that is entirely inconsistent with the law the California Legislature has adopted pursuant to the Elections Clause," Bennett said. "How can we do that?"

Matthew Donnelly, a Justice Department attorney, said the Trump administration has good reason to believe those ballots are from ineligible noncitizen voters, and has the legal right under separate federal criminal law to challenge their tabulation until state officials can prove otherwise.

Donnelly said both federal criminal law and state election law bar noncitizen voters from casting ballots, but "the problem is that California isn't interested in enforcing that provision."

The exchange came during an hour-long hearing before a three-judge panel of the U.S. 9th Circuit Court of Appeals, over the Justice

[See **Court,** A5]

A clash between tech, content roils Netflix

BY WENDY LEE, MEG JAMES AND SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

As Netflix grapples with fallout from historic layoffs and upheaval in its senior executive ranks, the streaming giant is facing mounting scrutiny from investors about its growth strategy, diversification plans and response to rising competition from the likes of YouTube.

But the biggest challenge confronting the Los Gatos, Calif., company may be something more fundamental: a clash between the firm's roots as a technology-driven upstart and its ambition to be a force in Hollywood.

Increasingly, tensions have flared between the L.A.-based executives dedicated to movies and TV shows and its engineers and technologists in Silicon Valley. Internal disputes have erupted over how best to expand the business and promote content on the platform to boost audience engagement, according to former Netflix employees and industry insiders who spoke to The Times.

The friction has deepened since cofounder Reed Hastings stepped away from management, handing the reins in January 2023 to Ted Sarandos and Greg Peters, who share the job of chief executive.

The dual-boss structure has at times hobbled the company and contributed to muddled messages and some costly misfires, such as its foray in the games business, said the sources, who were not authorized to speak publicly due to the sensitivity of the topic.

"With two CEOs, it's hard to have a singular vision," said a former Netflix executive who was not authorized to speak publicly.

Netflix declined to comment for this article.

But a person close to the company disputed the claim that there was a culture divide in Netflix.

"The idea

[See **Netflix,** A11]



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GOV. GAVIN NEWSOM pauses while discussing floods in Pajaro, Calif., in 2023.

Ideal vs. real: Newsom on climate

After solid green start, record shifts with affordability

BY HAYLEY SMITH

Extreme drought, destructive flooding, deadly wildfires.

As California's 40th governor, Gavin Newsom has confronted the effects and causes of climate change in ways that few other state executives have, including his calls to "move beyond fossil fuels," and the setting of aggressive renewable energy goals.

Yet after Newsom's almost eight years in office, millions of Californians have been forced to contend with power blackouts, refinery closures and surging gasoline prices. At the same time, the Trump administration has sought to dismantle the state's boldest climate initiatives, calling Newsom's policies a disaster.

Now, as Newsom prepares to leave office in January and eyes a potential run at the White House, critics and supporters alike are reexamining his climate record, and its evolution from idealistic ambition to a politics more aligned with consumer affordability. Experts say Newsom's environmental legacy won't just define what's next for Califor-

[See **Newsom,** A8]

Democrat fights to hold Trump district

In a rare swing district in the West, voters seek independence as the key factor.

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL

LONG BEACH, Wash. — Tourist dollars are drying up in this small town at the edge of the Pacific Ocean. Foot traffic is down. Visitors have less to spend on souvenirs.

And beachgoers now bring packed lunches instead of stopping at Captain Bob's Chowder Sisters, said Melissa Huddleston, waiting for customers at her sister-in-law's shop on a recent Sunday.

Huddleston, 60, is depressed about the state of the country, and while she's planning to vote in the Nov. 3 midterms, she hasn't decided which candidate will get her vote. This swing district, Washington's 3rd, is home to a tight congressional race that will help determine the balance of power in the House.

Huddleston doesn't think anyone in Congress can really do what she wants: Bring decorum back to the national discourse and bring the economy back to life. She isn't a particular fan of Rep. Marie Gluesenkamp Perez, the independent-leaning Democratic incumbent, nor is she persuaded by state Sen. John Braun, the President Trump-endorsed Republican challenger.

"I don't know which one is better," Huddleston said, shaking her head. "I really don't."

As the battle to persuade midterm voters intensifies in the election's final stretch, its fever pitch is evident in places such as this largely rural stretch of southwestern Washington — a rare three-time Trump-voting district with a Democratic incumbent.

Groups aligned with Republicans are pouring money into flipping the district red, considering it one of the GOP's best chances to gain a House seat in an increasingly unfavorable environment, while Democrats see retaining the district as urgent to their effort

[See **District,** A4]

California group boosted Ohio attack ad

BY CLARA HARTER

As Ohio Republican gubernatorial candidate Vivek Ramaswamy came under fire for releasing an attack ad featuring his Democratic competitor's estranged mother, a mysterious news site was running a Facebook ad boosting the controversial video.

The Buckeye Bulletin, which bills itself as an Ohio-based news platform committed to "reliable journalism" and "strong editorial standards," popped up suddenly this spring and began pumping out a steady stream of pro-Ramaswamy content.

The publication's articles have no bylines. There is no list of staff. The website does not feature digital advertisements, nor does it prompt readers to subscribe, but there is also no disclosure of who is funding it.

A closer look at the Buckeye Bulletin's Meta advertising data shows that its Facebook and Instagram accounts are managed by the Lincoln Media Foundation, a nonprofit organization affiliated with the Orange County-based Lincoln Club — the oldest and largest conservative donor organization in California. IRS documents show that the club and foundation are associated organizations and share at least two key executives.

The Buckeye Bulletin, Lincoln Club and Lincoln Media Foundation did not

[See **Ad,** A5]



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A HALLOWEEN RARITY

A shift in weather at the end of the week could deliver the first rainy All Hallows' Eve in Los Angeles since 2014. **CALIFORNIA, B3**

Brazil's voters reelect Lula

Vocal Trump critic, 80, defeats the son of jailed former President Bolsonaro. **WORLD, A2**

Turning loss into Broadway magic

Billy Crystal spins a moving tale of losing his Pacific Palisades home. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 82/58. **B6**

Business **A10**
Opinion Voices **A13**

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